

Q You are also the co-founder of the Asterisk Documentation Project. What are the goals and key initiatives of this project? Has your experience with Fedora complemented this project or vice versa?

The skills I learned while driving the Asterisk Documentation Project helped make me want to become a contributor to Fedora and not just an end user. Asterisk also helped me change my focus from the technical side of things and branch out into the more human aspects of open source communities.

“I act as a conduit between the Fedora Community and Red Hat to make sure that both sides understand the other’s concerns.”

Q Please share a few details about your book *Asterisk, The Future of Telephony*. How is the future of telephony likely to evolve and what role will the open source technology stack play in this evolution?

After starting the Asterisk Documentation Project and successfully writing quite a bit of good Asterisk documentation, two friends (Leif Madsen and Jim VanMeggeelen) and I decided to write a book on Asterisk.

At the time, we subtitled the book *The Future of Telephony*. Since then, open source telephony has exceeded even my wildest expectations and now powers a very significant portion of the new telephone systems installed today. Leif and Jim have gone on to write a follow-up to the book but it no longer says ‘The Future of Telephony’ because the future is squarely here now.

Q Apart from technology, what are your other interests and how do they help you in your pursuits as the Fedora Project Leader?

I know some people are drawn to a very charismatic leader for their project, but I like to think of myself as an ordinary person outside of the world of free and open source software. My other interests include reading, hiking, spending time with my family, and singing in a church choir. I’ve also recently taken up photography and am slowly getting to the point where I’m not completely embarrassed to post some photos online.

Q Could you share a few insights regarding the cutting-edge technology projects in the Linux space that are currently under way? What is your involvement with them?

I don’t have the time these days to spend much time programming, but I do see myself as a catalyst to help drive development in other ways. I try to help get the right people sharing ideas, help the next generation of developers learn the tools and skills they’ll need, and inspire people to take a more active role in the future of free software.

On open source adoption and the money in FOSS

Q Often people say that while open source solutions are available at a low cost or for free, the support cost or the service engineers hired to run the show are a scarce resource, and the overall costs of running the IT infrastructure on open source solutions is ultimately higher than the proprietary solutions. What is your take on this perception?

You could argue that the overall costs of an administrator who understands open source might be slightly more expensive. My own experiences have shown that open source administrators scale better. Just as one piece of anecdotal evidence—I previously worked at a company where we had a staff of six or seven full-time administrators managing over 6,500 Linux servers and all the related networking. At the same company, we had four or five full-time administrators managing the company’s dozen Windows servers. I don’t expect everyone’s experience to be the same as mine, but I don’t give much credence to the notion that the total cost of ownership is higher for free/open source solutions.

Q There is a view that it is difficult to make money around FOSS. What is your take on this?

Of course it’s difficult to make money around FOSS. I’d argue that it’s difficult to make money around software in general, and doubly so in FOSS because you have to go out and prove your value every single day.

You don’t get to take short-cuts or play marketing tricks to convince people to buy the latest version of your software. The transparency in FOSS means any one of your competitors can see what you do and how you do it and try to do it better. There’s no ‘secret sauce’.

That being said, there are a number of profitable open source companies that are successful because they understand the dynamics of FOSS and consistently prove their value day after day. I consider myself very privileged to have been able to work for two such companies over the past few years.

Q What would be your advice to young FOSS professionals who want to build businesses or careers around FOSS?

I think it’s naive to think that a future employer won’t search for your name on the Internet before calling you in for a job interview. What better way is there to impress your future boss than to have your name out there associated with development of code you are passionate about and working as part of a team?

FOSS in software development

What are the advantages of working on open platforms and using open source tools for software development? What key advantages does the open source stack offer vis-a-vis the proprietary ones, in relation to: individual developers/